

Reading

PREPARING TO READ

A BUILD VOCABULARY The words in **blue** are used in the reading passage. Read the text below. Then write the correct form of each word next to its definition.

While it would be easy to assume that most languages have a lot in common, the rules are a lot more different than we might assume. By applying a little bit of **scrutiny** to the English language, for example, we can identify many features that aren't the same in other languages.

The use of tense is an obvious example. English uses different verb forms to indicate when something happened, happens, or will happen. However, not all languages have those verb forms. In fact, many use just one verb form with different time expressions—such as yesterday, today, or next week—to provide context.

And what about pronouns? English uses gendered pronouns when referring to people in the third person. Again, this is a distinction that doesn't always exist in languages. In some languages, just one word is used for both *he* and *she*, or *her* and *him*. Other languages have pronouns that don't even have English **equivalents**. Such languages could, for example, have two forms of *we*: one that refers to me, my friends, and the person I'm speaking to; and another that includes me and my friends, but not the person being addressed. To speakers of these languages, the English version of *we* could be seen as a **limitation**.



▲ In Maori, *tāua* means *you and I*, *tātou* means *all of us*, and *mātou* means *I and them, but not you*.

Peer into the inner workings of any two **random** languages and you'll inevitably find many other differences like these—differences that could affect the way people string together thoughts and **conceive** new ideas. A new language is therefore not just a collection of new words: it's a new **paradigm** for interpreting life in general.

1. _____ (v) to look at something closely
2. _____ (adj) not planned; left to chance
3. _____ (n) a shortcoming, or a weakness
4. _____ (n) an equal, or a counterpart
5. _____ (v) to imagine or think of something
6. _____ (n) close inspection
7. _____ (n) a model or an example one uses to understand a concept

B BUILD VOCABULARY Complete the sentences below with the correct form of the words in **blue**. Use a dictionary to help you.

abstract (adj)
horizon (n)

coherent (adj)
hospitality (n)

dread (n)
stereotype (n)

glimpse (n)
texture (n)

1. Traveling can help you learn new things and expand your _____.
2. The thought of speaking to people in a new language fills many language learners with _____.
3. His movie explores several themes that are _____ and difficult to define.
4. Her use of different languages and dialects in the script gave it a rich _____.
5. You don't have to use impressive words in your presentation. You just have to be _____.
6. Documentaries can only give you a(n) _____ of what life is like in other countries.
7. I was grateful for the _____ they showed me when I visited them last year.
8. They think teenagers are all lazy and irresponsible, but that's just a bad _____.

C USE VOCABULARY Discuss these questions with a partner.

1. What are some **stereotypes** that exist about people from your country?
2. How do you show **hospitality** to others in your culture?
3. Do you think that learning a new language expands your **horizons**? If so, how?

D SCAN The reading passage expands on the topic of words with no English equivalent. Search the reading passage for non-English words and write them down in the chart below. Then, search for their meanings and write them in the chart, too.

Words with no English equivalent	English translation

E SYNTHESIZE Look at your answers to question 3 on page 124. Add the words you thought of and their meanings to the chart above.

Critical Thinking

Is Joy the Same in Every Language?

by Jen Rose Smith



The Arabic term *tarab* can be used to describe the intense emotions felt by this dervish dancer in Dubai, U.A.E.

“The lexicon¹ of a foreign language is like a map of a country you’ve never been to,” says psychologist Tim Lomas, a lecturer at the University of East London.

- A**  While travelers tend to think that seeing the world is central to understanding it, some language experts shift the **paradigm**: to them, it is actually words that shape our perspectives on the world. Studying words therefore offers a window into the human experience.
- B** To these researchers, dictionaries are like maps. They help define the topography² and **textures** of our world, and they can lead the way to discoveries. Next to traveling, learning new words—or an entire language—may be the most mind-expanding journey of all.
- C** As a word collector, Tim Lomas makes an excellent tour guide. He studies the words we use for our emotions, dreams, and desires—words that vary widely across the world’s 7,117 spoken languages. His research constitutes a global glossary of feelings.

A WORLD OF EMOTIONS

- D** Languages from Aleut to Zulu contain unique terms for our internal lives, and Lomas has gathered thousands of them into an interactive lexicography. The searchable index of words is sorted by language and theme, and drawn from every part of the globe.
- E** His collection, featuring categories such as “revelry”³ and “longing,” brims with treasures: Roll your tongue around the German word *zielschmerz*, for example, to imagine the thrilling **dread** of finally chasing a long-held dream. Or crank up your stereo and channel the Arabic *tarab*, a state of enchantment⁴ or ecstasy that only music can induce.
- F** Some such words are a journey in themselves. The Wolof term *teraanga* is a spirit of **hospitality**, generosity, and sharing that permeates life in Senegal, where travelers enjoy a warm welcome traditionally extended to guests.
- G** And Lomas’s own lexicon is inspired, in part, by travel. More than two decades ago, a teenaged Lomas spent six months roaming around China—a trip that introduced him to far-ranging cultures and belief systems. “China had such detailed theories about the mind, well-being, and emotional states,” he says. “I could definitely appreciate that lots of this fell outside my conceptual **horizon**.”
- H** “There are real **limitations** if we only view our emotional lives through the prism of English,” he says. It’s a belief that he brings to his psychological research. If you want to understand the human mind, Lomas suggests, you have to look beyond your own culture.

¹ **Lexicon** refers to the entire collection of words in a language or field.

² **Topography** is a geological term that describes the features of an area of land.

³ **Revelry** refers to celebration and having fun.

⁴ A person feels **enchantment** when experiencing something extremely beautiful or magical.

ARE THERE UNTRANSLATABLE WORDS?

- I You may recognize some of the words in Lomas’s collection from the lists of “untranslatable” words that have taken the internet by storm in recent years. They include terms such as *hygge*, the Scandi-inflected pleasure of cozy comfort, and *sisu*, a kind of stoic⁵ grit celebrated in Finland.
- J Many language experts are skeptical of such lists. “Often, they hew suspiciously close to **stereotypes** about the culture in question,” writes David Shariatmadari in his myth-busting linguistics⁶ book *Don’t Believe a Word: The Surprising Truth About Language*.
- K The very idea of words being “untranslatable” doesn’t stand up to much **scrutiny**, either, Shariatmadari explains. After all, such lists of words invariably go on to include perfectly good translations. Instead of “untranslatable,” it’s more accurate to say they lack a one-word, English-language **equivalent**.
- L Here’s the real surprise: This is the case not just for ultra-specific words like *hygge* and *sisu*. When it comes to feelings, one-to-one exact translations are less common than you might think. Even terms such as happiness, sadness, and anger—which seem basic to English speakers—are not universal and don’t exist in every language.
- M Take “happy,” for instance. Flip through a Polish-English dictionary, and you’ll find the term *szczęśliwy* offered as a direct translation. But the Polish word is actually different, said the late Polish poet Stanisław Barańczak, who translated emotion-rich works by authors including William Shakespeare and Emily Dickinson into his native language.
- N While happiness can be casual, *szczęśliwy* is set aside for “rare states of profound bliss, or total satisfaction with serious things such as love, family, the meaning of life,” Barańczak wrote in the book *Emotion and Cause: Linguistic Theory and Computational Implementation*. The emotional contours of *szczęśliwy* are different from that of happiness. What first appears to be an easy translation is anything but.



The Polish word *szczęśliwy* describes rare states of bliss that come from serious things, such as love and family.

WHY WORDS MATTER

- O When learning a new language, students have been known to paste tiny vocabulary stickers all over the house, turning furniture into memory-jogging flash cards. But if words are just labels, why does it matter how we refer to emotions?
- P Some researchers believe that words can subtly shape the way we see the world. One such researcher is neuroscientist⁷ Kristen Lindquist at the University of North Carolina, who has found that the words we use play an important role in turning experiences into recognizable emotions. She described the process as a kind of categorization, like slipping an experience into a mental filing cabinet.

⁵ A stoic person shows little or no feeling even through difficult or bad times.

⁶ Linguistics is the study of how languages function.

⁷ A neuroscientist studies how human brains work.

Q “The brain automatically and implicitly engages in categorization all the time,” Lindquist says. As an example, she describes the desktop display on her computer, which has a photo of a mountain on it. Tiny pixels of light beam out at her from the screen, and her brain uses categories acquired through experience—she’s seen plenty of mountains—to interpret the image. Without such categories, which rely on language, the display would be just a **random** smattering of color.

R “That’s the process by which any emotional experience is coming into being,” she says. “The concepts that we know, especially for categories such as emotion, which are really **abstract** categories, are supported in large part by the language that we speak.”

S Using a theory called psychological constructionism, Lindquist explains how an emotion, such as joy, might arise. First comes a constellation⁸ of thoughts, sights, smells, and other experiences. Your brain uses existing categories, she says, to sort those incoming sensations into something you can make sense of.

T **Peer** inside each of those categories, and you’ll find impressive variety, Lindquist says. Feelings can be fuzzy, free-floating, and hard to define, but words help group them into something more **coherent**. “Language serves as the glue,” she says.

THE POWER OF LANGUAGE LEARNING

U Learning a new language might start to make that glue more flexible. “There are all sorts of differences in terms of how finely you break down your categories,” says Aneta Pavlenko, a linguist at the University of Oslo. Pavlenko argues that becoming bilingual or multilingual can restructure those categories, expanding the ways we **conceive** of emotions.

V “Maybe you see things as a single type of anger, but now you need to see them as three or four different varieties,” she says. The same goes for joy, delight, or even love.

W Pavlenko warns that simply picking up some flash cards won’t reshuffle your brain’s emotional categories. To do that, you need to put the new vocabulary to use, preferably in a situation where you’re sure to talk about feelings.

X But even if you’re not making cross-cultural small talk in Tagalog or Urdu, language study can still be a mind-expanding experience, says Lomas. While poring over a map isn’t the same as actually exploring the nooks and crannies of an unfamiliar landscape, it does hint at the shape of things—just as learning new words gives a **glimpse** of just how expansive the world of emotions can be.

Y “It’s trying to appreciate how people live and experience life,” Lomas says. “And I think words can do that.”

Adapted from “Is joy the same in every language?” by Jen Rose Smith: National Geographic, January 2021

Jen Rose Smith is a Vermont-based travel writer with a B.A. in linguistics from the University of California at Berkeley. She speaks French, Spanish, Portuguese, and Latin.

⁸ A constellation is a collection of stars.



Language learners don’t just learn new words, but a new way to make sense of the world.

UNDERSTANDING THE READING

A UNDERSTAND MAIN IDEAS Match the paragraphs to their main ideas.

- | | |
|------------------------|---|
| 1. ____ Paragraphs A–B | a. To explore how humans think, Lomas put together a collection of words from different languages that describe emotions. |
| 2. ____ Paragraphs C–H | b. Even simple, everyday words often don't have one-to-one equivalents in other languages. |
| 3. ____ Paragraphs I–K | c. The words we know determine the way our brains classify and define objects and concepts. |
| 4. ____ Paragraphs L–N | d. Words from different languages give us insight into different countries and cultures. |
| 5. ____ Paragraphs O–T | e. Learning a new language allows us to form more precise descriptions of the world. |
| 6. ____ Paragraphs U–Y | f. It is important not to read too much into lists of highly specific words with no English equivalent. |

B UNDERSTAND DETAILS Read the statements. Choose **T** for true, **F** for false, or **NG** for not given.

- | | |
|--|---------------|
| 1. Lomas's index focuses on words for emotions because such words are usually different across cultures. | T F NG |
| 2. In English, words for emotions tend to be less specific than in other languages. | T F NG |
| 3. <i>Szczęśliwy</i> describes a casual state of general happiness. | T F NG |
| 4. According to Lindquist, words are a way to categorize, and therefore define, abstract concepts. | T F NG |
| 5. Learning a new language helps us improve our proficiency in our first language. | T F NG |

Critical Thinking

C INFER MEANING Find and underline the following words and phrases in the reading passage. Use the context to identify their meanings. Then write the correct form of each word or phrase next to its definition.

permeates (paragraph F)	skeptical (paragraph J)	invariably (paragraph K)
smattering (paragraph Q)	nooks and crannies (paragraph X)	expansive (paragraph X)

- _____ expressing a distrust of certain information
- _____ small, hidden spaces
- _____ wide in terms of size or scope
- _____ to spread through something completely
- _____ a small group of things randomly spread around
- _____ always; without fail